

THE NUMBER OF ROMAN EMPERORS THAT RULED BETWEEN 235 AND 284



Roman emperor Gordian III succeeded his father and grandfather.

IN CHINA, THE FINAL COLLAPSE OF THE HAN DYNASTY IN 220 was followed by 350 years of instability. The **Three Kingdoms** period (220–80) saw China divided into the **Wei** kingdom of the north; (initially under Wei Wendi (r. 220–26); the **Shu Han** kingdom in the west whose first ruler was Shu Han Xuande (r. 221–23); and the southern **Wu** kingdom under Wu Wudi (r. 222–52). Wei Wendi was a capable ruler, but his successors struggled to contain attacks by northern tribesmen.

In 235, the Roman emperor Alexander Severus and his mother Julia Mamaea were **murdered** by mutinous troops, putting an **end to the Severan dynasty**. The uprising's ringleader, **Maximinus Thrax** (r. 235–38), an officer from a humble background, was proclaimed emperor, but he spent most of his reign raising funds to reward his troops for their support. This time marks the start of a period of **"military anarchy"** in which Rome had dozens of emperors, most of them short-lived rulers who were raised up by the frontier armies and just as quickly deposed and killed. A rebellion in 238 in North

Africa proclaimed the province's elderly governor as **Emperor Gordian I**, but he was quickly and brutally put down. The Senate declared Maximinus deposed and proposed **Pupienus** and **Balbinus** as candidates. Popular sentiment favored Gordian I's grandson



Art from the Three Kingdoms

High artistic achievements, such as this fine statue, were a feature of the late Han dynasty. Its collapse in 220 did not result in an equivalent decline in China's artistic output.



KEY

- Wei, 220–225
- Shu Han, 221–263
- Wu, 222–280

China under the Three Kingdoms

Although the Wei kingdom faced the greatest challenges among the three kingdoms, it would eventually conquer the Wu and the Shu Han.

Gordian III (r. 238–44), so all three briefly shared the throne. Balbinus and Pupienus were killed soon after, leaving Gordian III to rule alone. His six-year reign **briefly restored** some semblance of **stability** to the empire, but he was killed while leading an invasion of Persia in 243–44. Compounding the Roman Empire's difficulties was the appearance of **barbarian confederacies** among the Germanic peoples of the Rhine and Danube frontiers. Principal among these were the **Alemanni**. In 213, Caracalla campaigned against them; by 260 they were able to **invade Italy** itself.



A mural of St. Cyprian, Bishop of Carthage at the height of the Decian persecution. He was martyred in 257 during a campaign under Valerian.

PERSIA ATTAINED A POSITION OF RENEWED STRENGTH under Shapur I (r. 241–72). In 244, he won a decisive battle against Gordian III at Misiche near Ctesiphon. Shortly after, Gordian III was killed and replaced by his army commander Philip (or **Philip "the Arab"**). Philip made peace with Shapur but had to pay a large ransom to escape Sasanian territory. His successors broke the terms of the agreement, so in 256 **Shapur I invaded Syria** and captured the towns of Antioch and Europos Dura. **Valerian**, who by then was emperor (r. 253–60), soon retook Antioch. In 260, he fell into a trap and was **imprisoned by Shapur**. The Romans were left

in disarray and Shapur's armies advanced as far as Iconium (modern Konya, Turkey).

The western part of the Roman Empire also faced increasing pressure. The Romans suffered invasions of Dacia (much of modern Romania) by the **Carpi** people from c. 214. The Carpi, together with a new group, the **Goths**, took part in a raid across the Danube in 239–40. In 248, Emperor Philip **withdrew an annual tribute** he had been paying the Carpi and the Goths, prompting them to pour into Moesia (modern Bulgaria). Philip sent **Quintus Decius** to deal with the invasion; he was so successful that his troops declared him emperor. Early in 249, Decius marched to Rome and defeated and killed Philip. Hearing of the Roman civil war, the **Goths invaded again**, causing Decius to return to the Balkans in 250. Under their warleader **Cniva**, the

Relief of Shapur I

In this relief, Shapur I triumphs over the Roman emperors Gordian III and Valerian. After Valerian's capture, Shapur is said to have used him as a footstool for mounting his horse.

